Gravity and Testimony

By Maura O'Connor

INTRODUCTION

We turn on the radio, we flip on the television, but when the song is over, or the movie ends our emptiness returns. We grow up in the paradigm that life consists of what we observe going on around us, on the surface of the earth. However, this Surface Life soon becomes mundane, so we seek to fill it up with things and activities. Yet this too becomes insignificant. Eventually we feel the emptiness of our lives and see the hollowness of our existence. So we begin to search for meaning . . . the following two poems, Gravity and Testimony give us insight into Maura O'Connor's search for meaning.

Gravity

Today I am fragile

pale

twitching

insane and full of purpose.

I'm thinking we tend our illnesses

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as if they are our children:

fevered

screaming

demanding attention and twenty dollar bills, hours we

could have spent

with the television on.

Faith is a series of calculations made by an idiot savant.

I'm in love.

I'm alone

in this city of painted boxes stacked like alphabet blocks

spelling nothing.

There are things I know:

trees don't sing

birds don't sprout leaves

the sky never turns to wine

roses bloom because that's what roses do, whether we

write poems for them

or not.

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I concentrate on small things:
ivy threaded through chain link,
giveaway kittens huddled in a soggy cardboard box, a fat
man blowing harmonica
through a beard of rusty wires
brown birds chattering furiously on power lines.

I try not to think about
lung cancer, AIDS,
the chemicals in the rain;
things I can't imagine any more than a color I've never
seen

My heart is graffiti on the side of a subway train, a
shadow on the wall made by a child.
Nothing has been fair since my first skinned knee I
believe death
must be.

I cling to love as if it were an answer. I go on buying
eggs and bread, boots and corsets,

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knowing I'll burn out before the sun.

I'm thinking of
the days I tried to stay awake
while the billboards and T.V. ads
for condoms, microwave brownies, and dietetic jello
lulled me to sleep.

A brown-eyed girl once told me a secret that should
have blown this city
into a mass of unconnected atoms Our sewage is piped to
the sea. Beggars in the street
are hated for having the nerve
to die in public.

Charity requires paperwork, Relief requires medication

as if we were the afterthoughts of institutions greater
than our rage.

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Gravity chains us to the asphalt with such grace we
think it is kind.

We all go on buying lottery tickets, Diet Coke and
toothpaste
as if the sky over our heads
were the roof of a gilded cage.

We provide evidence that we were here: initials cut into
cracked vinyl bus seats, into trees growing from squares
in concrete,
a name left on a stone, an office building, a flower, a
disease, a museum
a child.

Tonight the stars glitter like rhinestones on a black
suede glove.

In the coffin my room has become,
I talk to God
about the infrequency of rain

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about people who can't see the current of gentleness
running under the pale crust of my skin.

I tell him under
the jackhammer crack, the diesel truck rumble, even the
clicking sound traffic lights make switching from yellow
to red,
there is a silence
swallowing
every song,
conversation,
every whisper made beside graves.

I tell him I can't fill it with dark wine, blue pills, a pink
candle lit at the altar

God doesn't answer.
God doesn't know our names.

He's only the architect designing the places we occupy
like high rise offices or ant hills

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I know this
the way I know
sunrise and sunset
are caused by the endless turning of the Earth.

Testimony

These days
I cover my face with bottled skin and scented creams
stain my lips the color of rose juice wear black
my eyes deepen

The man who once called me that girl in the white shirt

He carried me home in a magician's casket cut me in two
I came out whole

I'm a kindness to climb into

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a Dresden doll found in the basement of a burnt house

These days
I buy the book with the ugliest cover comb the thick
orange hair
of the innocent child
I never was

While my heroes are knocked down like pinatas
while we wear surgical gloves
to the laying on of hands

I've folded suicide in four
laid it on a bare white shelf
someday it may gather dust
I might toss it away like an old dishrag I'm young
green as bread mold

I'm seeking witness

I want the testimony of Hitler

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Stalin
the shadows on the bricks of Nagasaki

These days
the newspapers serve a menu of clay pigeons bring your
own bullets

I want to ban the colors of the television the perfect
thighs
and plastic wishes
I want to burn Jesus leaflets
and wear his sandals

I'm taking it all off
in the bars of my rib cage

While the politicians find work for each idle child
while two terminal patients
place bets on the existence of God

These days

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I show the years when I didn't want to live in the gray
spokes of my iris
I'm coming apart like a ten-cent toy

I carry my head under my arm like a rag doll

I want to sleep in the ruin
of last night's makeup
I want ancient recipes over instant rice

I want to find the hummingbird graveyard I want to fill
my mouth with black beetles and walk the edge of Eden

I need a new commandment

I will collect single bars of old songs I will weep a page
of black ink
I will be an unprotected witness

My country serves three-day notice
to the starving

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my country's hands are tattooed

on the belly of a battered child

my country sleeps in the snow of the television after its

anthem is played

Let's burn the country and keep the flag

This night is falling in pieces this moon is cream on a

raisin sky

I will evolve thick skin and filter I will plan my next

breath

I will watch the four riders foam their horses into glue

It isn't over yet

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Maura O'Connor
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